

NO BAGGAGE Nayab Saini takes oath as the new CM on March 12; (right, sitting) his mentor and predecessor, M.L. Khattar

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YOUNGER LEGS FOR THE RACE

Farm-fresh, caste-positive and no baggage—that's what Khattar protege Nayab Singh Saini brings to the table as the BJP attempts a political makeover just before a brace of crucial polls in Haryana

BY ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

THE UNEXPECTED IS TO BE EXPECTED: that's by now a motto in the BJP's tactical playbook. But it always leaves a vast pool of possibilities. Where—rather, against whose name—would the roulette's needle stop? The tall, lanky, bearded figure of Nayab Singh Saini is where it decided to stop on March 12. Soft of manner and speech, and perhaps even of ambition, the 54-year-old MP from Kurukshetra may have been as surprised as Manohar Lal Khattar was back in 2014 when picked as the chief minister of Haryana. The latter had an equally surprising exit clause sprung on him, six months short of a decade in office. Just the previous day, as he walked down the spanking-new Dwarka Expressway with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the 69-year-old Khattar had seemed supremely secure in saddle and stirrup. Saini, an OBC, is counted among those loyal to him, but wasn't ever really